

The Unification of China

The rise of the dynamic Qin state, which conquered the Warring States of China to create the Chinese empire, brought a period of stability and prosperity to China. Under the short-lived but ambitious rule of the First Emperor (221–206 BCE), the laws and infrastructure of imperial China first took shape.

BEFORE

As China moved out of the Bronze Age, the Shang were defeated by the Zhou, the last of the pre-imperial dynasties.

THE ZHOU DYNASTY

The Zhou dynasty (1027–256 BCE) lasted **longer than any other in Chinese history**. During the Zhou period, bronze was widely used, and



ZHOU BRONZE

iron technology was introduced in China. The Zhou dynasty saw the **birth of the major indigenous Chinese philosophies**, including Confucianism **131 >>**, and a system of government that had many **similarities to the European feudalism of the Middle Ages 188–91 >>**.

THE WARRING STATES PERIOD

The Zhou rapidly **disintegrated into a number of independent states**, and from 481 BCE, the start of the era known as the Warring States Period, **regional warlords** were conquering smaller states around them to consolidate their rule.

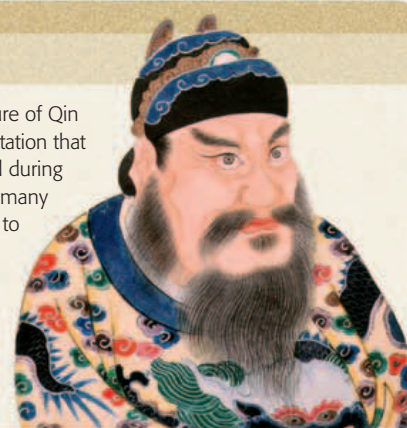
The terra-cotta army

The First Emperor's mausoleum was constructed near Xi'an by 700,000 conscripts. In 1974 a chance find led to the uncovering of four pits containing over 7,500 life-size and lifelike terra-cotta soldiers, horses, and chariots (left). The scale of the mausoleum is a testament to the power of the First Emperor. Today, the terra-cotta army is visited by two million people every year.

FIRST QIN EMPEROR (260–210 BCE)

QIN SHI HUANG

Later Confucian historians have painted a picture of Qin Shi Huang as a ruthless megalomaniac, a reputation that can be traced to two notorious acts committed during his reign. The first of these was the burning of many classical texts that were being used by officials to argue against his decisions, and the second was the alleged burying alive of 460 scholars for disagreeing with him. Yet whatever his failings as an ideal ruler, the achievements of the man who unified China for the first time cannot be underestimated.



One of the territories to survive the Warring States period was the state of Qin. The people of Qin were situated to the west of Zhou territory along the Yellow River valley—so far west that people said they shared the customs of the Rong and Di, non-Chinese groups regarded as uncivilized. In 316 BCE, Qin began a series of campaigns against the other warring states, and in 221 BCE the king of Qin defeated the last remaining state and declared himself Qin Shi Huang (see below), the First Emperor of Qin.

Qin Legalism

In 356 BCE, before the Qin had even begun to conquer the surrounding states, Lord Shang, an exponent of Legalist ideas, became chief minister of Qin. The Legalists opposed the Confucian ideals of filial piety and kingly benevolence (see p.131). Instead, they argued that the interests of the state came before those of individuals, that rulers should apply strict laws and punishments, and that the use of war as an instrument of state policy was acceptable. Lord Shang began a program of Legalist reform in the state of Qin, where all adult males were registered for military service. Perhaps unsurprisingly, considering its emphasis on the infallibility of the head of state, the First Emperor was an advocate of Legalism. During his reign, Li Si, the chief minister, put Legalist principles into practice and introduced measures that are still in effect throughout China today. Among these measures were the abolition of the feudal fiefs (see BEFORE), the standardization of the written script, the application of a strict legal code,

the establishment of official measures for weights and lengths, the issue of a unified currency, and even the regulation of the width of roads.

The Qin Empire

Though the Chinese empire had already been created by the conquest of the Warring States, Qin expansion continued southward. Expeditions were sent to modern Guangdong, on the south coast of China, and Chinese colonies were established there.

After campaigning against the steppe peoples in the north, the emperor ordered his general Meng Tian to construct a great wall to establish

QIN Pronounced "Chin"—a Chinese dynasty and a likely origin of the English word for China.

control over the Ordos region of Inner Mongolia, in order to help repel further incursions from the steppes. This was the first phase of the Great Wall of China, which was later rebuilt during the Ming dynasty (see pp.166–67). Meng Tian also constructed the Straight Road, which ran 500 miles (800 km) north from the capital Xianyang to the Ordos region to facilitate movement of military troops.

As well as constructing works that enhanced China's defenses, Qin Shi Huang also commissioned many grand public building projects—including palaces, bridges, and canals—to strengthen imperial rule in China.

An immortal tomb

As he grew old, the emperor became increasingly obsessed with finding the secret of immortality. This obsession led to the most ambitious building project commissioned by Qin Shi Huang—the construction of his own mausoleum—which began in 212 BCE. According to the description recorded a century later by the Grand Historian, Sima Qian, the tomb contained a model of the empire, which had rivers of quicksilver and a mechanism for operating the tides, and was guarded by traps that would shoot any intruders after the tomb was closed. Not far from this burial chamber (which has yet to be excavated) stood the terra-cotta army (see left), a legion of life-size pottery soldiers that were constructed to defend the First Emperor in death.



Qin-dynasty coins

Round coins with a square hole, similar to those used in China until the late 19th century, first appeared during the Qin dynasty.

Qin Shi Huang died in 210 BCE on an expedition to the east of China in search of the island of Penglai, where immortals were believed to reside.

Fall of the Qin

After the death of the First Emperor, his son took power, but he was never as effective a ruler as his father, and he was forced to commit suicide by his chief minister two years later. China crumbled into civil unrest and much of Qin Shi Huang's work was lost. Palace archives were burned, destroying evidence of the period. Revolts and uprisings led to the demise of the dynasty less than twenty years after it had begun.

AFTER

The Legalist ideas of the Qin were rejected by the Han dynasty, but the influence of Qin Shi Huang was felt in China for centuries.

CHINA AS ONE

Following the short-lived Qin dynasty, the expectation that China should be a **unified state** remained strong up to modern times.

A NEW EMPIRE

The Han empire **128–29 >>**, which followed the Qin dynasty, was to last for 400 years. The Han dynasty **rejected Legalist principles in favor of Confucianism**, and the influence of this philosophy in state affairs is still felt today.

LEGACY OF THE FIRST EMPEROR

Historically, **the rule of the First Emperor was seen in a negative light** by scholars, and his cruelty and obsession with immortality were highlighted. In more recent years, modern

China has come to reevaluate Qin Shi Huang's aims and achievements in political and social terms. Mao Zedong **424–25 >>** **praised the First Emperor for his achievements** and endorsed his attack on Confucianism.



MAO ZEDONG